

Consumer Perception of Counterfeit products: Authenticity, Contagion, Distance, and Affect.

Introduction and Background

Consumer perceptions of counterfeit products have become a central topic in psychology and marketing research, not only because counterfeit markets continue to grow but because these products challenge fundamental assumptions about authenticity, value, and moral judgment. Foundational work highlights that people intuitively treat authenticity as a transferable “essence,” with contagion principles influencing judgments about products, ownership, and brand meaning (Newman & Dhar, 2014; Rozin et al., 1986). Newman and Dhar (2014) demonstrate that products manufactured closer to a brand’s original source are perceived as more authentic, even when objectively identical; Rozin et al.’s (1986) work on the laws of sympathetic magic argues that physical contact, proximity, and symbolic association can transmit desirable or undesirable properties. When applied to counterfeits, these insights raise critical questions: can fake products inherit the “essence” of the genuine? Does proximity, whether geographic, symbolic, or psychological, amplify or diminish this inheritance? And how do these perceptions interact with moral, emotional, and identity-driven responses?

This review synthesizes findings from ~60 empirical and conceptual papers published between 1980 and 2025 across major academic databases. Studies span psychology, consumer behavior, marketing, and branding research. Five themes emerged that form the structure of this review: (1) contagion and authenticity, examining how consumers infer essence transfer; (2) geographic and psychological distance, detailing how production location and psychological abstraction modulate authenticity and moral engagement; (3) moral and affective reactions, focusing on disgust, perceived wrongdoing, and moral disengagement; (4) motivations for counterfeit consumption, addressing economic, symbolic, and identity-related drivers; and (5) the interplay between counterfeit and genuine brands, highlighting when counterfeit experiences dilute, enhance, or transform perceptions of originals. Together, they reveal how consumers make sense of counterfeits as well as key gaps in the literature, which can aid future work on how authenticity is constructed in counterfeit contexts and how essence transfer, distance, and affect jointly shape consumer perception.

Methodology

The review draws from systematic searches across major academic databases (Google Scholar, JSTOR, ScienceDirect, ResearchGate, and UofT Libraries) using keywords such as *counterfeit products*, *authenticity*, *contagion*, *country-of-origin*, *psychological distance*, *moral disgust*, and *consumer perception*. Approximately two hundred articles were screened based on relevance to psychological and perceptual evaluations of counterfeits rather than business or policy outcomes. After removing duplicates and extraneous topics, fifty-nine studies were included and grouped into thematic clusters and additional literature, from which dominant concepts and relationships were extracted for synthesis.

Thematic Review and Synthesis

Theme 1: Contagion and Authenticity

Research consistently shows that consumers intuitively treat authenticity as something that can be transmitted, strengthened, or weakened through physical contact, production proximity, or symbolic similarity. Newman and Dhar (2014) demonstrate that consumers judge products made in original factories as carrying more “brand essence,” even when they are identical in quality to those manufactured elsewhere. Their experiments show that perceived essence is tied to production proximity and physical linkage to the brand’s origin, highlighting a contact-based model of authenticity transfer. This view aligns with long-standing work on sympathetic magic. Rozin et al. (1986) show that people believe both desirable and undesirable properties can transfer through physical touch or proximity. Their findings emphasize material contact and object history as key drivers of essence perception. This “laws of contagion” framework would suggest that counterfeits sharing the same materials, manufacturing processes, or touch points as originals should inherit some of the original’s authenticity.

While these foundational studies argue that contagion effects depend primarily on direct physical cues, others show contagion can also be symbolic. For example, Nemeroff and Rozin (2018) claim that even abstract associations, such as a brand’s heritage or cultural narrative, influence judgments of authenticity. This could lead to different predictions for counterfeit evaluations. If physical contagion dominates, then counterfeits produced near the original factory or using original-like materials will feel more authentic. If symbolic contagion dominates, then counterfeits that replicate brand history, cultural cues, or identity markers may appear authentic even without physical proximity. An expertly branded counterfeit with strong storytelling could potentially feel more authentic than a physically similar one with no symbolic connection. Nevertheless, current literature has not reconciled these two pathways, leaving open questions about which cues consumers privilege when judging counterfeit authenticity.

Beyond the distinction between physical and symbolic contagion, studies show that consumers use a wide range of cues, temporal, tactile, intentional, moral, and semiotic to infer authenticity or contamination. Smith et al. (2016) demonstrate that consumers perceive earlier serial numbers as more authentic because temporal closeness to the creator is treated as essence-enhancing, extending contagion beyond physical contact to creation proximity. Argo et al. (2006), however, show that contact from other consumers often reduces perceived value through unwanted contamination. Morales and Fitzsimons (2007) further argue that even brief contact with “disgusting” items can transfer negative essence; this suggests that the direction of contagion, positive vs. negative, depends heavily on who or what imparts it. Stavrova et al. (2016), who find that contamination can occur even without touch if the intentions behind an object are morally tainted, further reinforce that essence transfer may follow psychological rather than physical pathways.

As such, counterfeits introduce additional layers of complexity. Amar et al. (2018) show that counterfeit products can “infect” genuine ones through *moral* disgust rather than physical similarity, suggesting that symbolic or ethical contamination can override positive authenticity cues. Carsana and Jolibert (2018) complement this by showing that indexical cues (e.g., production traces) boost perceived authenticity more strongly than iconic cues (e.g., visual similarity), implying that consumers privilege signals tied to real production processes over superficial resemblance, which is directly relevant to how counterfeits are evaluated. Finally, Nunes et al. (2021) highlight that consumers hold multifaceted notions of authenticity (indexical, iconic, moral, and existential), helping explain why some counterfeits feel deceptively “authentic” while others evoke disgust or inauthenticity despite being materially similar.

Together, these studies show that authenticity perceptions draw from both tangible and intangible contagion cues, often producing contrasting evaluations depending on which pathway is most salient. Understanding this distinction is crucial for predicting when counterfeits may inherit “brand essence” and when they instead provoke perceptions of inauthenticity or moral taint.

Theme 2: Country-of-Origin and Geographic / Psychological Distance

Building on Theme 1's insight that authenticity can be "transferred" through proximity, Theme 2 shows that geographic, territorial, and psychological distance shapes how consumers infer authenticity and legitimacy. Meta-analytic evidence demonstrates that country-of-origin cues reliably shift perceptions of quality and authenticity, with products made in a brand's home country consistently evaluated more positively than identical products produced elsewhere (Verlegh and Steenkamp, 1999). This aligns with Newman and Dhar's (2014) production-lineage findings. However, Verlegh and Steenkamp (1999) argue that such effects arise not only from contagion-like intuitions but also from broader cultural stereotypes and national competence beliefs.

Bilkey and Nes (1982) first establish that country-of-origin functions as a strong heuristic: products associated with the "right" place receive higher authenticity and quality evaluations, reinforcing the idea that physical or cultural closeness to the origin signals essence continuity. They find that when consumers expect counterfeiting to be widespread in certain regions, proximity no longer signals authenticity, instead it activates suspicion. Cheah et al. (2016) argue that even ingredients from an origin-country can enhance authenticity perceptions in luxury brands. In contrast, Zhang and Merunka (2015) show that territorial cues operate through both competence beliefs and perceived cultural fit, and that authenticity judgments depend on whether the place aligns with the brand's identity, not simply on geographic proximity.

Psychological distance also shapes authenticity judgments. Trope and Liberman's (2010) construal-level theory shows that distant objects are processed abstractly, making diagnostic cues like production or ingredient origin less influential. Edwards et al. (2009) extend this to online shopping contexts, finding that lack of physical interaction, or even temporal delay, increases psychological distance and reduces perceived similarity and familiarity, often suppressing moral or quality concerns. Bian et al. (2022) demonstrate the opposite pattern for some counterfeit consumers: higher construal levels can increase counterfeit patronage by making consumers focus on abstract values (e.g., self-expression or affordability) rather than concrete authenticity cues. Their findings contrast with Edwards et al., suggesting that psychological distance can either dilute or facilitate counterfeit acceptance depending on whether authenticity or value motives are foregrounded.

These studies show that distance interacts with the authenticity contagion. Geographic closeness strengthens authenticity only when cultural expectations match brand identity; psychological distance can either undermine authenticity sensitivity or empower consumers to disengage from it entirely.

Theme 3: Moral and Affective Reactions

This theme centres on disgust, moral disengagement, and perceived risk when consumers evaluate counterfeits. Veloutsou and Bian (2008) identify perceived legal, functional, and especially social risk as a central affective barrier. Even when counterfeits look authentic, consumers anticipate reputational loss or moral stigma, indicating that negative affect can override positive essence or proximity cues. Augusto de Matos et al. (2007) find that attitudes toward counterfeits are shaped by simultaneous moral concerns and pragmatic considerations; many consumers experience moral ambivalence, where the appeal of low-cost luxury coexists with discomfort about deception or exploitation. This helps explain why COO or authenticity cues sometimes fail to meaningfully shift evaluations.

Furthermore, Cesareo and Bellezza (2025) show that moral reactions hinge on consumers' knowledge about counterfeiting harms: when consumers understand ethical and societal consequences, moral condemnation increases sharply, but when knowledge is low, moral disengagement becomes easier. This aligns with Bian et al. (2016), who find that consumers employ active moral rationalization strategies, such as euphemistic labeling, denial of victimhood, and diffusion of responsibility, to reduce guilt and justify counterfeit purchase. In other words, moral affect is not fixed, but shifts depending on whether consumers choose to foreground or suppress ethical considerations.

Eisend's (2019) meta-analysis clarifies these patterns by showing that morality consistently predicts counterfeit avoidance across studies, but its strength depends on context and product type. The analysis helps reconcile contradictions between findings: moral emotions exert strong influence when activated, but they can be strategically muted by consumers

motivated to justify counterfeit use. Finally, Marticotte and Arcand (2017) introduce a counterintuitive affective pathway: *schadenfreude*. They show that for some consumers, pleasure at undermining luxury brands increases counterfeit purchase intentions, illustrating that moral affect can also be positively valenced and brand-antagonistic rather than purely guilt-based.

Unlike Themes 1 and 2, where authenticity and distance influence perception, Theme 3 shows that emotional processes can dominate evaluations, sometimes even amplifying concerns about contamination or wrongdoing. This variability sets the stage for Theme 4, where motivational drivers must be understood as operating against a backdrop of shifting moral emotions and selective engagement with counterfeit products.

Theme 4: Motivations and Purchase Intentions

Theme 4 shows that motivations for buying counterfeits emerge from the interplay of identity goals, emotional regulation, perceived risk, and self-authenticity concerns. Perez et al. (2010) demonstrate that counterfeit luxury goods function as identity-construction tools, allowing consumers to project a desired self even when they lack access to genuine luxury. Their work aligns with Wilcox et al. (2009), who argue that counterfeits help consumers signal status while avoiding the financial costs of authentic goods, supporting the idea from Themes 1 and 2 that symbolic cues can outweigh material authenticity. However, Rosely (2021) presents a contrasting narrative: rather than status signalling, many consumers use counterfeits as a satisficing strategy to fulfill fashion wants without emotional strain or financial guilt, highlighting a more pragmatic, self-soothing motivation.

Risk and knowledge moderate these motivations. Bian and Moutinho (2011) find that brand image and product involvement strengthen purchase intention, but knowledge about counterfeits increases perceived risk and reduces willingness to buy. This contrasts with Jiang and Cova (2012), who show that in China, counterfeit consumption is normalized and even celebrated as an expression of “luxury love,” allowing consumers to bypass risk concerns entirely. Dovalienė (2014) adds nuance, finding that attitudes toward counterfeits are shaped by expectations of quality and social acceptance, suggesting that perceived authenticity and social norms jointly influence motivation, sometimes in opposite directions.

Finally, Gino et al. (2010) show that wearing or using counterfeits can decrease self-authenticity and increase dishonest behavior. This psychological cost contradicts the identity-enhancing benefits highlighted by Perez et al. and Wilcox et al., implying that counterfeit consumption may foster a “counterfeit self,” one that satisfies short-term identity or aesthetic goals but erodes self-concept in the process. This also directly challenges the contagion-based assumption that counterfeits can inherit positive essence from the original. Instead, counterfeits may introduce a negative self-contagion effect, lowering self-worth even as they meet functional or symbolic goals.

Overall, these studies reveal that consumers balance aspirational identity needs, pragmatic satisficing motives, cultural norms, and internal authenticity concerns when purchasing a counterfeit product. These motivational tensions help explain the inconsistent downstream effects on genuine brand perceptions explored in Theme 5.

Theme 5: Interplay Between Counterfeit and Genuine Brands

Theme 5 examines how counterfeit use reshapes perceptions of genuine brands, revealing that spillover effects depend on the interaction of authenticity beliefs (Themes 1-2), moral responses (Theme 3), and motivations (Theme 4). Stöttinger and Penz (2015) show that consumers often own counterfeits and genuine products concurrently, but the relationship shifts over time; initial counterfeit use can serve as a low-risk entry point into a brand, yet prolonged use may either strengthen aspiration toward the genuine or diminish its symbolic value as consumers recalibrate what the brand represents. This dynamic aligns with Bian and Moutinho (2011), who find that counterfeit ownership can reduce perceived uniqueness of the genuine brand, weakening brand equity, particularly when consumers view the counterfeit as sufficiently similar or authentic along key attributes.

However, similarity does not always predict negative outcomes. Van Horen and Pieters (2012) demonstrate that high-similarity copycats often suffer from comparative evaluation, highlighting their inferiority, while moderate-similarity copycats may benefit from positive associations without inviting direct comparison. This means that for genuine brands, very close counterfeits can backfire, whereas moderately similar ones may actually reinforce brand meaning. Amaral and Loken (2016) add that social identity moderates these effects: for status-oriented consumers, counterfeit use can dilute perceptions of the genuine brand, while for lower-status consumers, counterfeit use can enhance the perceived prestige and desirability of the authentic brand, underscoring the motivational asymmetries introduced in Theme 4.

Other studies emphasize category and consumer-type differentiation. Le Roux et al. (2019) reveal that product category (e.g., conspicuous vs. functional goods) and consumer motivation profiles determine whether counterfeit ownership leads to dilution or enhancement. Their findings complement Penz and Stöttinger (2008), who argue that counterfeits and originals share overlapping symbolic functions, making substitution or contamination effects more likely in highly image-relevant categories. Meanwhile, Astray et al. (2021) show that the quality of the counterfeit shapes attitudes toward the genuine brand through associative judgments: high-quality counterfeits can generate positive spillover if consumers attribute quality to the underlying brand, but low-quality counterfeits tend to degrade genuine-brand evaluations via negative association.

A consistent negative pathway emerges in Commuri (2009), who finds that consumers deceived into purchasing counterfeits often blame the original brand for failing to safeguard authenticity, leading to anger, distrust, and relationship deterioration. This moral contamination effect echoes the contagion and disgust findings of Themes 1 and 3, where negative experiences with counterfeits can symbolically “infect” perceptions of the genuine brand even when the brand is not directly responsible.

These studies show that spillover from counterfeits to genuine brands is not inherently damaging or beneficial, but conditional. Effects depend on similarity, consumer identity motives, counterfeit quality, category relevance, and whether the consumer feels agency or victimhood in the encounter. This interplay reflects the themes of the broader review: authenticity cues (Themes 1-2), moral affect (Theme 3), and motivations (Theme 4) jointly shape how counterfeit experiences ultimately transform consumer-brand relationships.

Discussion

Across themes, several patterns emerge: consumer responses to counterfeits depend on how authenticity, morality, and identity intersect under varying conditions of distance and symbolism. Consumers treat authenticity as both transferable and fragile, guided by contagion intuitions, country-of-origin cues, and psychological distance. Additional literature shows how these authenticity judgments operate within broader cultural and generational frameworks. For instance, Hanzae and Taghipourian (2012) document age-linked divergences in counterfeit acceptance, while Nakassis (2012, 2013) demonstrates that in some cultural settings, “brandedness” itself supersedes authenticity, making symbolic markers more important than lineage or material contact. These insights affirm that authenticity is not a fixed construct but a socially negotiated one, shaped by local norms and expectations.

Themes 3 and 4 show that moral affect and identity motives further modulate these judgments. Some consumers experience moral tension or self-incongruity when using counterfeits, while others reframe counterfeits as tools for identity construction or value satisfaction. Additional work reinforces this motivational complexity: Bassoli (2010) highlights the symbolic fulfillment counterfeit goods can provide, and Rutter and Bryce (2008) show that counterfeit consumption is often embedded in social play rather than strictly deviance. At the same time, meta-analytic evidence (Eisend et al., 2017) confirms substantial cross-cultural variability in the psychological drivers of counterfeit use, suggesting that motivations cannot be easily generalized. This aligns with Theme 4’s finding that consumers balance economic, symbolic, and moral motives in ways that often override or complicate authenticity cues.

Theme 5 reveals that counterfeit experiences can transform perceptions of genuine brands, although in inconsistent directions. Some studies indicate dilution (e.g., loss of exclusivity or trust), while others show enhancement if counterfeits stimulate aspiration or emphasize brand distinctiveness. Nia and Zaichkowsky (2000) show dilution effects under high counterfeit prevalence, whereas Romani et al. (2012) and Wang et al. (2024) demonstrate conditions under which counterfeits can actually heighten the appeal of genuine brands. Bellezza and Keinan (2014) add that non-core users (including those who rely on symbolic rather than authentic brand contact) can increase brand pride among core users. These mixed findings underscore a theoretical gap: existing research rarely integrates authenticity, contagion, motivations, and moral affect into a single explanatory framework, even though spillover effects may depend on all three.

Several gaps remain. First, empirical work seldom tests whether counterfeits vary in perceived authenticity based on relative geographic proximity to the original. Second, almost no studies were found to examine “creator effects,” such as whether counterfeits made by former factory workers or artisans associated with the brand carry heightened perceived authenticity. Third, although psychological distance appears crucial, research has not systematically investigated how online shopping, supply-chain opacity, or time delays modulate authenticity contagion or moral disengagement beyond a few specific contexts. Fourth, studies often rely on narrow product categories (especially fashion and luxury), limiting generalizability to non-luxury counterfeits or high-involvement goods. Methodologically, many papers use hypothetical or vignette-based approaches without manipulating contagion, distance, or production cues directly, leaving causal processes under-specified. Future work would benefit from experiments comparing multiple counterfeit types that systematically vary in proximity, symbolic connections, or creator identity, as well as multimethod designs incorporating real product handling or origin information.

Conclusion

Overall, the literature shows that consumer perceptions of counterfeits arise from the interplay of contagion-based authenticity judgments, distance cues, moral emotions, and identity-driven motivations. While each component has been studied independently, few studies examine how they interact to shape evaluations of both counterfeit and genuine brands. Empirical tests of proximity-based authenticity transfer between counterfeits, the influence of creator identity, and the ways in which psychological distance in digital contexts reshapes moral and authenticity judgments are promising directions for future research. Addressing these gaps would significantly advance theoretical understanding and provide a more integrated account of how consumers construct and negotiate authenticity across counterfeit and genuine products alike.

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